

HISTORY HACK · DOCUMENT-BASED QUESTION

The Origins of the Cold War

US.60 — Analyze the Cold War policies of containment and the Truman Doctrine, Marshall Plan, and Berlin Airlift.

TEACHER EDITION — scoring guide and expected evidence. Not for student distribution.

Name _____ Class _____ Date _____

Directions. Read the following three primary source excerpts and then respond to the prompt below. In your response, analyze each document using the HIPP framework (Historical context, Intended audience, Purpose, Point of view) and construct an evidence-based argument.

The sources

Document A

George Kennan, "The Long Telegram," February 22, 1946 — declassified U.S. State Department cable, available through the National Archives

“We have here a political force committed fanatically to the belief that with US there can be no permanent modus vivendi, that it is desirable and necessary that the internal harmony of our society be disrupted, our traditional way of life be destroyed, the international authority of our state be broken, if Soviet power is to be secured.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT A

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

Document B

Winston Churchill, "The Sinews of Peace" (Iron Curtain Speech), Westminster College, Fulton, Missouri, March 5, 1946 — public address, transcript available through Westminster College archives

“From Stettin in the Baltic to Trieste in the Adriatic, an iron curtain has descended across the Continent. Behind that line lie all the capitals of the ancient states of Central and Eastern Europe... all are subject in one form or another, not only to Soviet influence but to a very high and in many cases increasing measure of control from Moscow.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT B

H — Historical context

What was happening when this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how does that shape it?

Document C

Harry S. Truman, Address to Congress (Truman Doctrine), March 12, 1947 — U.S. government document, National Archives

“At the present moment in world history nearly every nation must choose between alternative ways of life. The choice is too often not a free one. One way of life is based upon the will of the majority... The second way of life is based upon the will of a minority forcibly imposed upon the majority.”

SOURCE IT — DOCUMENT C

H — Historical context

What was happening when
this was made?

I — Intended audience

Who was meant to read or
hear it?

P — Purpose

What was it trying to make
the audience do or think?

P — Point of view

Who is speaking, and how
does that shape it?

The question

Using all three documents and your knowledge of Cold War origins (US.59-US.60), construct an argument that evaluates the relative roles of ideology and geopolitical strategy in causing the Cold War. Apply HIPP analysis to at least two of the three documents and use outside historical knowledge to support your argument. Your response

1. what each document reveals about U.S./Western perceptions of the Soviet threat
2. whether the Cold War was primarily an ideological conflict or a geopolitical competition for power; and
3. whether alternative outcomes were possible given the structural conditions of 1945–1947

Plan your answer

Your claim	
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Source	Evidence you will use	Why it supports your claim
Document A		
Document B		
Document C		
Outside knowledge		

Write your response

Scoring guide

Pts	6-point scale
6	Exemplary. Presents a precise, historically arguable thesis on the ideology/geopolitics question. Applies full HIPP analysis to at least two documents, identifying historical context, audience, purpose, AND point of view for each. Uses outside historical evidence (minimum 3 specific facts) not from the documents. Addresses all three prompt components: perceptions, causation debate, and alternative outcomes. Demonstrates sophisticated understanding of historiographical debate.
5	Advanced. Clear thesis. Full HIPP applied to two documents (may be incomplete on one element for one document). Two pieces of outside evidence. Addresses two of three prompt components thoroughly.
4	Proficient. Arguable thesis. HIPP partially applied to two documents (addresses 2–3 elements per document). One piece of outside evidence. Addresses at least two prompt components.
3	Adequate. General thesis. Analyzes at least two documents but without systematic HIPP. Uses document evidence but limited outside knowledge. Addresses one prompt component clearly.
2	Developing. Basic claim. References at least one document but analysis is mostly summary. Minimal outside evidence. Prompt components addressed superficially.
1	Beginning. Attempts a response. May reference documents but without analysis. Little to no outside evidence. Does not address prompt components.
0	No response or off-topic.

Expected evidence and document analysis. DOCUMENT ANALYSIS EXPECTATIONS: For Document A — HIPP should identify Kennan's diplomatic vantage point, State Dept. audience, warning purpose, and his trained diplomat's point of view that shaped his perception. For Document B — HIPP should note Churchill's political status, the American audience (Truman present), the galvanizing purpose, and Churchill's imperial Great Power point of view. For Document C — HIPP should identify the immediate Greece/Turkey crisis, the congressional audience, the funding request purpose, and Truman's Manichean framing as a political strategy. KEY EVIDENCE EXPECTED: Yalta and Potsdam tensions; Soviet satellite states (1945–1948); Soviet rejection of Marshall Plan; Berlin Blockade (1948–1949); Soviet atomic test (1949); Chinese Communist victory (1949); NSC-68 (1950) as ideological escalation.

Sourcing. Every document above carries its own citation as written in the item record. Verify each against the holding institution before classroom use — an unsourced primary source is worse than a missing one.

